

Try this exercise, putting a/an/the in the blanks. If there should be no article, then place a * in the blank. The answers and explanations follow.

Mr Coleman was (1) ____ very fastidious person. He lived three (2) ____ streets away from us, in (3) ____ small house with (4) ____ beautiful garden. Having taken early retirement from his (5) ____ job as (6) ____ button counter, he now had plenty of time to worry, and this he did very successfully. He often spent sleepless nights trying to figure out how he could successfully cook *both* sides of (7) ____ omelette without it breaking, or how he might achieve better access to (8) ____ tins at (9) ____ back of his cupboard. (10) ____ most of his home was exceptionally neat and tidy, but several loose cables behind (11) ____ television set bothered him, and he never quite knew what to do with (12) ____ empty plastic bags.

Then, one day, his life changed, and he began to experience some relief from his anguish. It seemed that other people underwent similar mental trials, for (13) ____ new catalogue appeared on his doorstep. (14) ____ catalogue contained solutions for many of his problems, and for others which had not yet given him any cause for concern. There was (15) ____ set of three egg timers, for example, shaped like (16) ____ chickens and designed to emit (17) ____ clucking sound at (18) ____ end of three, four and five minutes respectively. In this way he could cook (19) ____ eggs to suit each of his friends individually, and then keep them warm with (20) ____ specially designed covers which went with the timer, marked '3', '4' and '5' for identification purposes. And (21) ____ catalogue contained many other wonderful ideas, such as (22) ____ toaster which could be adjusted to produce different degrees of brownness on (23) ____ four slices toasted simultaneously, and (24) ____ photo frame that rotated pictures at (25) ____ touch of (26) ____ invisible button, so that visiting relatives would never be offended by not seeing their pictures on display, unless, of course, they all turned up together – Mr Coleman eventually solved this problem too by ordering four frames.